A Culinary Journey

SHORT STORIES & TALES

Fuel for the food we serve

J. D'Costa Andrade

CONCEPTIONAL FINE DINING

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Before We Begin

The beginning of our journey

This is NOT a cookbook. And even if it were, it wouldn't be one of those where you try to replicate a recipe step by step, praying it somehow works out, just because some (star) chef decided to dump his "infinite wisdom" all over you. None of that "look what a genius I am" bullshit that leaves you frustrated in a trashed kitchen that looks like you invited two Mexican wrestlers to settle a score.

So before you burn the place down, fry your brain, your wallet and your time: the majority of cookbooks out there are complete bullshit. Yeah. I said it. Loud and clear. Why? Because the "star chefs" slapping their names on the cover of their holy grail almost never wrote the damn thing themselves. And hey, I can't even blame them, they're cooks for God's sake, not writers. But even if they did: the average guy would still find it impossible to actually cook from it. You'd end up like Tyler in Mark Mylod's "THE MENU", killing yourself because your "vision" shattered against reality. Granted, a little dramatic, that film.

Here's the one thing you really need to understand if you ever want to pull off a real meal: it's NEVER about the recipe. Not about a purely sensory experience either, while we're at it. If it were, 99% of restaurants worldwide would have to shut down immediately. What actually makes a dish great stands waaaay (not a typo, just an emotional hiccup) above any recipe. How the hell do you write a book about how to live a perfect life anyway? What would the ingredients even be?

That doesn't mean recipes are useless, the entire French culinary elite would have my head if I left it at that. Recipes have their place, but only as guidelines. Don't believe me? Try this: pick a recipe, call a buddy and cook it completely independently, point by point, exactly as written. Then get together and eat the lab experiment. I'm telling you right now: it will taste different. Similar, sure, but different. Because food is fundamentally "magic", and magic refuses to be pinned down on a piece of paper. Which is exactly why you'd want to strip a Michelin-starred chef of his stars over the phone. After all, we're talking about someone who makes his living knowing how to handle a meat cleaver.

Where the Hell Do I Even Start?

** Amuse - Bouche **

" I slipped into this world right at the stroke of noon, as if the universe decided to screw up lunch right from the start. "

Beginnings are a pain in the ass. They're chaotic, incomplete and mostly bullshit anyway, like trying to pinpoint the exact moment a hangover kicks in after a night of terrible decisions.

But fine. Let's just call this an introduction to my persona.

Hi, my name is Joe. Well, at least that's the name I gave this character, because it's short, sharp and makes it damn hard to pin me down without digging deeper. And that's exactly how I like it. Maybe it's because I've spent my life trying to figure out who I actually am and where I come from. Or maybe because I hate being shoved into boxes, with those neat little labels people love to slap on you like price tags at a flea market. No, amigo, I'd rather be discovered, explored, peeled back layer by layer. Like a wine that carries more than what's printed on the label. Alright, let's get into it.

I slipped into this world right at the stroke of noon, as if the universe decided to screw up lunch right from the start. Born in some godforsaken place at the ass end of nowhere, I was loaded into a fruit crate with a pillow straight after birth, et voilà, instant peasant-style crib. Cute, right? Except my parents (God bless their hopeful souls) bolted shortly after, chasing dreams in a colder, greyer place. A place that promised opportunity but delivered food so bland you could have used it as a torture device.

We're talking meals that tasted like regret wrapped in cardboard. Even as a kid I had this instinct: people who care about good food can be trusted. Everyone else? Suspicious bastards with something to hide.

While other twelve-year-olds were stacking blocks on the playground, I was already planning my escape: warmer weather, honest food and a permanent Adiós to that grey,

Kapitel 1

Monsieur Saint-Jour

** Tony's Oyster **

"It tasted of seawater. Of brine and flesh.And somehow, of the future"

France, 1966. Forget Paris. Forget white tablecloths and cathedral ceilings and waiters who look down their noses at your pronunciation. This is a petrol-reeking, barnacle-crusted wooden boat wallowing in the grey, indifferent waters of the Bassin d'Arcachon in southwest France. Not a yacht. A workhorse. The kind of vessel that groans under nets and buckets and the occasional wave that smacks you across the ass like a wet towel.

The boat belongs to Monsieur Saint-Jour. A fisherman who looks like a drunk sculptor carved him out of driftwood, cured with decades of salt air. Ancient denim that could write its own memoirs. A beret. A knife that looks like a prop from a pirate film, sharp enough to crack an oyster or fend off a shark..

On board: a ten-year-old kid from New Jersey named Anthony. Yeah. That Anthony. The future chain-smoking, bourbon-soaked culinary poet who would one day pin his entire twisted, improbable career on a single ugly shellfish. Tony's roots ran back to France, his father was of French descent, with ties to this very region.

Saint-Jour reaches into the murk and hauls up a jagged, mud-crusted rock. *"Une huître!"* An oyster. Ripped straight off the tidal beds, still pulsing with something primordial and alive. He cracks it open right there on the deck. The shell weeps seawater and slime. He turns to the family. *"Mange. C'est la mer. La vie à l'état pur"*

Tony sees his shot.

Not just for a snack. For glory. To out-brave his father. To horrify his little brother. To catapult himself, with one bold, stupid, magnificent slurp, from boyhood into something else entirely. He grabs the shell. Tilts his head back. Lets it in.

What hit him wasn't salt. It was the ocean itself, closing over his head. Briny. Metallic.

- Tonys Auster -

" Food without history is just calorie intake. When you sit at our table, we're not serving ingredients. We're serving history that turns a meal into a revelation"

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The dish: A single, hand-selected Gillardeau oyster. The Rolls-Royce of the form. Raised in the pristine, cold waters near Marennes-Oléron, a stone's throw from Tony's Arcachon. Served raw and unpolished, resting not on silver but on coarse salt from the Marais salants de Guérande. The best salt in the world. The right bed for the right oyster.

The ritual: Eat it the way Tony did. No hesitation. No fork. Just you, the shell and whatever the sea decides to say. A mignonette built from the oyster's own natural liquor, sharpened with twelve-year-old Cabernet Sauvignon vinegar. Head back. Slurp. Let the ocean crash into you.

Kapitel 2

Pietro Querini

** Baccalà **

" The Ocean doesn't give a fuck about your ego"

Pietro Querini. Venetian merchant with balls of steel. A man who looked at the North Atlantic in 1431 and decided he could take it. Picture him on the docks in Candia, that's modern-day Crete for you millennials out there. Silk robes. Gold rings on hands that had never seen a blister. Strutting like God's own gift to international commerce. His ship, the Querina, is loaded to the waterline with Malvasia wine, sweet enough to talk a monk out of his vows, pepper and ginger that burn hotter than a scorned lover, cotton bales, candle wax and everything else the Mediterranean trade routes scream "profit" at. Sixty-eight men in his crew. Hard, scarred, pirate-tested sailors. A handful of knights for appearances. Servants to polish the man's boots. They sail on April 25th, headed for Bruges, that rain-soaked Flemish trading post where deals get hammered out over bad beer and worse herring. Easy run, Querini brags over his last good chalice of wine. Easy money. The man is already spending his ducats in his head.

But the ocean doesn't give a damn about your cargo manifest or your ego. It waits. Cold and moody and absolutely indifferent to Venetian ambitions. They clear Gibraltar. Hug the French coast. Then the storm hits like a divine gut-punch. Winds that howl like something biblical. Waves crashing over the deck taller than palazzo walls. The ship screams, beams split, sails shred like wet paper. December 17th they abandon her. Two lifeboats. One disappears into the spray with forty-seven souls. Gone. Just like that. Querini and fifteen survivors cling to the other and drift north across the North Sea like corks with nothing left to lose.

Weeks. No land. No fresh water. Just salt spray in open wounds and the slow knock of madness at the door. They chew leather straps. They hallucinate. Venetian courtesans with Chianti-bottle curves. Eyes dark as midnight sins. Querini writes in his diary, the

- Cicchetti Baccalà -

We serve history. The kind that reminds you food has as much to do with survival as it does with seduction. Baccalà Pietro Querini is our tribute to that shipwrecked epiphany.

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The dish: Premium Norwegian stockfish from the icy Lofoten waters. Soaked for days. Beaten tender. Whipped into a Baccalà Mantecato cream with garlic, olive oil and herbs that would make Querini weep with recognition. Served on polenta or grilled bread. That firm bite. That deep salt hit. The sea, nodding.

The ritual: No cutlery. Fingers only. Like you're rationing on a raft and this might be it. Eat slowly. We'll hit you with a fine mist of salt water to simulate the Norwegian gale. Staffing levels permitting. Feel that? Good. That's the whole point.

Why you need to try it: This isn't a starter. You're chewing on the bones of

- Family Album -

Before We Begin

"If you suddenly feel the urge to speak to 'the manager'... that's Joe! (the guy above)."

About the Author

J. D'Costa Andrade

Entrepreneur, consultant, foodie, author, and stoic thinker.
With A Culinary Journey, he presents his literary debut. Although not born in Germany, the original work was deliberately written in German, an homage to a childhood and early years spent there. As a multifaceted mind, he combines technological progress with sociological inquiry. When asked, the author jokingly describes himself as a modern Renaissance man: a polymath with Gypsy roots. Today, after a lifetime as a nomad, he lives and works in his adopted home, Spain.